



Akohekohe
(*Palmeria dolei*)

As people have moved from place to place, they have brought with them a variety of animals. Some, such as rats and mosquitoes, came by accident. Others, such as cats, mongooses, and stoats, were brought deliberately as pets or to control pests. But introduced animals ended up preying on local birds that had no defense against these intruders. This was a particular problem on islands, where many bird species are flightless or lived on the ground. On the Pacific islands, populations of ground-nesting seabirds have halved because of introduced rats and cats. And nearly half the songbird species on the Hawaiian Islands have been wiped out by diseases such as malaria, carried by introduced mosquitoes. Because they had never been exposed to malaria before, birds such as the Akohekohe have not developed immunity and so the disease kills them quickly. Stoats were introduced into New Zealand to try to control the rising numbers of rats and other small mammals. Unfortunately, they raided the eggs and chicks of the South Island takahe, a rare flightless bird, and it almost became extinct as a result.

Introduced species

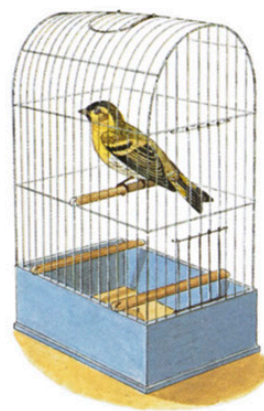
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Stoat
(*Mustela erminea*)



South Island takahe
(*Porphyrio hochstetteri*)



Caged songbird

Today, parrots make up more than three-quarters of traded bird species, with most coming from the tropical Americas and Africa.

Trade in caged birds

Many people like to keep birds in cages or aviaries as pets because of their beautiful colors, their songs, or their company. Birds are trapped all over the world, and this has threatened many species with extinction. Unfortunately, large numbers of birds die during capture, while waiting to be sold, or on their journey to a life in captivity. For every 10 birds caught in the wild, only about one may ever reach a pet shop. In the past, songbirds such as finches made up about 80 percent of birds traded this way—with parrots making up most of the rest. In 2005, the European Union set up a ban that reduced bird trade by a staggering 90 percent, but shifted the



Pollution

The activities of people and industry release harmful chemical substances into the environment, and these can threaten birds. Chemical pesticides and fertilizers used on crops, poisonous fumes released from factories, and accidental oil spills can all damage habitats and

the birds that live in them. In the 1960s, it was discovered that pesticides could build up in food chains and kill top predators such as birds of prey. In much of the world, controls on pollution are now in place to help protect habitats from its effects, but birds are still being poisoned in many countries. In recent years, plastic pollution has become a major concern—especially in ocean habitats. Today, 90 percent of seabirds are accidentally eating plastic, leaving less room for their actual food. Meanwhile, global warming caused by burned fossil fuels is melting polar ice, changing polar habitats and disrupting the migration patterns of birds.

The end of the line

Some birds have died out completely. One example is the dusky seaside sparrow. Until the 1940s, thousands of these small songbirds lived in the salt marshes on the east coast of Florida, in the United States. Then in the mid-1950s, Cape Canaveral and the Kennedy Space Center Visitor Complex were built on these marshes and dykes were constructed to stop the tidal flooding. The sparrows needed the floodwaters to provide food for their survival, so they soon began to die out. Some birds were protected in a wildlife refuge, but in 1975, fire destroyed their habitat and no females have been seen since. The last dusky seaside sparrow died in 1987.

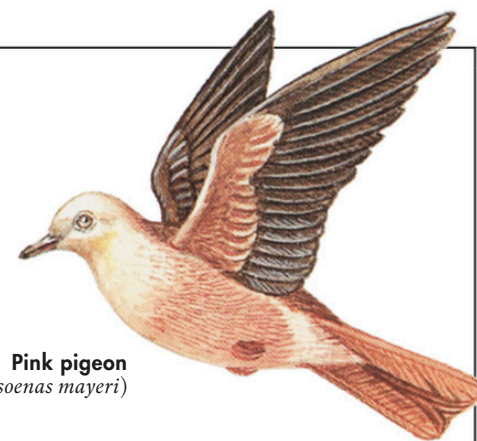
Dusky seaside sparrow
(*Ammospiza maritima nigrescens*)



WHAT WE CAN DO TO HELP

The world's rare birds need our help if they are to survive. Birds are closely linked to all the other wildlife on the planet, so if there are problems for birds, these serve as a warning of problems for plants, animals, and people. We can help by doing the following:

- Set aside areas of land and water as nature reserves or wildlife sanctuaries where birds will be protected from disturbance, hunting, and introduced species.
- Set up more artificial feeding areas for birds to help them survive in harsh climates.
- Breed rare birds in captivity and release them back into the wild. Numbers of the pink pigeon were built up in this way.
- Ban the hunting of rare species and stop birds being shot on migration.
- Stop keeping wild birds in cages and use birds bred in captivity instead.



Pink pigeon
(*Nesoenas mayeri*)

- Reduce the amount of pollution, especially from oil spills and pesticides.
- Carry out research to find out as much as possible about how birds live, so we can plan the best ways to conserve them.
- Pass international laws to protect endangered species.
- Join conservation organizations to protest, raise money, and make other people aware of the problems.